India’s 600-odd districts belong to this migration wave at present, and most of these have experienced mass outmigration for several decades, if not centuries. In a few districts, outmigration has waned in intensity, while in some others the intensity has picked up only in recent decades. There are also districts left untouched by the migration wave, with many other regions acting as destinations, namely plantations, towns and cities. The Great Indian Migration Wave can be disaggregated by geographic regions, and the starkest divide occurs between the coasts and the hinterlands.

We begin our exploration of India from a particular part of the west coast that stretches from Ratnagiri to Kerala, bounded by the sea on one side and the Western Ghats on the other. It is a scenic destination and figures on many recommended road and rail trips. If you travel there today, you will also notice the proliferation of Western Union boards and the general lament about the shortage of labour. That is because this stretch of land is one of the most remittance-dependent regions in the world. That this stretch also constitutes a relatively more developed part of India in terms of incomes and education levels suggests that it is not just a simple story of poverty driving migration. What unites this region is the historic connection with Mumbai via steamers since the late 19th century and the evolution of a tradition of migration eventually transcending that city.

For instance, few people would associate Goa, of all places, with outmigration. However, Portuguese Goa, like the Konkan, had turned from an ‘agrarian to a remittance-based economy’ in the late 19th century.[38] Sex ratios were elevated, reflecting mass male migration, and remittances financed Portuguese Goa’s trade deficit with British India. Next to those beautiful beaches, people lined up at the ports to head towards Mumbai and other destinations to meet the ‘demand for personnel who could meet European tastes in food, drink, music, dress and medicine’ and where Christian migrants worked as ‘cooks, stewards, butlers, musicians, tailors, ayahs and bakers’.[39] Baking was such a significant activity that Goan Catholics earned the sobriquet of being *maca pao*s, a phrase still commonly used in Mumbai.